

Middle-order pivot: The skipper, Suryakumar Yadav, has dropped to No. 4, making space for Tilak Varma's at No. 3. GETTY IMAGES



A new generation, but familiar questions remain

India names a **fresh-look squad** for the Asia Cup, with Shubman Gill as vice-captain. Big calls see Shreyas Iyer and Yashasvi Jaiswal miss out.

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Such is the glut of T20 talent in India that the absence of Rohit Sharma and Virat Kohli, the country's two most prolific batters in the format, barely registers as the Men in Blue prepare for their first multi-team white-ball tournament since the retirement of these stalwarts.

The supply line is so crowded that

even proven performers, Shreyas Iyer and Yashasvi Jaiswal, have been nudged out of India's 15-member squad for the Asia Cup in the United Arab Emirates.

The competition is fiercest at the top of the order, where Rohit and Kohli thrived for more than a decade. That battle intensified once Shubman Gill (**facing page, right**), fresh from a prolific Test tour of England as captain, was parachuted back into the squad despite more than a year away. The Ajit

Agarkar-led panel has backed him as a future all-format leader and named him vice-captain, making his place a certainty. **His inclusion almost certainly breaks up the Abhishek Sharma-Sanju Samson opening pairing that powered India through the past year.** Gill will likely partner Abhishek, the top-ranked T20I batter, leaving Samson displaced and vulnerable — not just as an opener but also as wicketkeeper, with Jitesh Sharma waiting as a proven finisher. Gill's T20I strike rate of 139.27,